

Is free will compatible with determinism?

PHIL UA-78 Metaphysics

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The ability to do otherwise

'Free will' and our topic

The words 'free' and 'will' both turn out to lead down intellectually unproductive rabbit holes of terminological debate.

Most of the contemporary debate over 'free will' is really about the ability to do otherwise:

ATDO

x has the ability to do otherwise at *t* iff there is some kind of action such that, at *t*, *x* *can* do an action of that kind, but *will not* do an action of that kind.

The relevant reading of 'can'

Like other modal words, 'can' is probably to some extent context-sensitive.

We can try to pin down the reading we are interested in here as the one where 'x can do such-and-such' is equivalent to 'x has both the ability and the opportunity to do such-and-such'.

- So, pointing to a person sitting in jail and saying 'That person can play the piano, but is not going to play the piano' is not enough to establish that they have the ATDO.

Another thing people sometimes say to try to narrow down the sense of 'can' at issue is that it is a sense in which it's true that one is *morally responsible* for doing something only if one *could* have refrained from doing that thing.

But it's actually controversial whether there is any ordinary reading of 'can' that is connected in this way with moral responsibility.

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There is a separate debate in ethics about the compatibility of determinism with *moral responsibility*. It has parallels with our debate about ATDO, but in principle all four combinations of answers are possible.

In a lot of the older literature, people tried to settle the debate about compatibilism by arguing for *analyses* (definitions) of 'can' (in the operative sense).

But this is very hard—in general, it's hard to settle disputes about the application of an ordinary word by arguing for an analysis of it, since the disputes are likely to carry over to whether the analysis is correct.

Better instead to just assume we understand this without a definition, similar to what we do for other ordinary notions involved in philosophical debates.

The burden of proof

We're mostly going to be looking at an argument for *incompatibilism*.

There's a sense in which the burden of proof is always on someone who wants to think that some *tricky claim about the structure of the laws of physics* is incompatible with some *commonsense claim about the ordinary world*. We're not going to spend a lot of time on questions like 'Is the conservation of charge compatible with the existence of great artworks?' unless someone has an argument that it isn't!

If the case of determinism and the ATDO feels different, that's plausibly because you're implicitly gripped by some argument, which it's incumbent on you to try to make explicit.

Compatibilism and incompatibilism

Compatibilism and incompatibilism

We are going to be focusing on the question whether it is metaphysically possible for someone to have the ATDO while determinism is true. 'Compatibilism' is the view that it is; 'Incompatibilism' is the view that it isn't.

While compatibilists pretty much always think that people in fact do often have the ATDO, among incompatibilists, there is more room for debate:

- ▶ Some—'libertarians'—think we can know we have the ATDO, and hence that determinism is false.
- ▶ Some think that we can't know whether determinism is true without doing a lot of experimental physics, and that we also can't know whether anyone has the ATDO without doing a lot of experimental physics.
- ▶ Some think that we can know without doing experimental physics that *no-one* has the ATDO. Among them, many think that it is *metaphysically impossible* for anyone to have the ATDO.

Other compatibilism debates

Determinism isn't the only thesis for which there's a debate about its compatibility with the ATDO.

- ▶ As we saw when we read the paper by Miller, there are some who deny that the **B-theory of time** is compatible with the ATDO.
- ▶ There are also some who deny that the mere existence of **facts about what will happen in the future** is compatible with the ATDO.
- ▶ And there are those who deny that the existence of an **omniscient God** is compatible with the ATDO.

Note that neither the B-theory of time, nor the existence of facts about the future, entail determinism: so you could combine the compatibilist view about these other debates with incompatibilism about determinism.

However, in the case of determinism life is harder for compatibilists, since there is an important *argument* for incompatibilism—the Consequence Argument—which doesn't work for the others.

If you can get compatibilism to work here, you're unlikely to have trouble defending compatibilism for the other debates.

The Consequence Argument

Settled for

The key thing we need to state the argument is the notion of a certain fact p being, as I'll put it, 'settled for' a certain person x at a certain time t . Intuitively: it's settled for me that p iff p and there's nothing I can do about whether p —it's not even partly *up to me* whether p ; I have *no choice about* whether p .

- ▶ Van Inwagen uses ' x couldn't have rendered p false'.
- ▶ Other authors spell out similar notions slightly differently—the exact wording turns out to matter more than one might have hoped.

The key connection to ATDO: if x can act in a certain way, then it isn't settled for x that x will not act in that way.

So every truth is settled for every person entails no one ever has the ATDO.

My rendition of the Consequence Argument

Past Necessarily, if x is a normal person at t , the complete truth about any initial interval earlier than t is settled for x at t .

Laws Necessarily, if x is a normal person at t and p is the conjunction of all laws of nature, p is settled for x at t .

Agglomeration Necessarily, if x is a normal person at t and p and q are both settled for x at t , the conjunction of p and q is settled for x at t .

Entailment Necessarily, if x is a normal person at t , p is settled for x at t , and p entails q , then q is settled for x at t .

Triviality So: necessarily, if determinism is true, x is a normal person at t , and p is true, p is settled for x at t .

Incompatibilism So: necessarily, if determinism is true, no normal person ever has the ATDO.

How is this related to van Inwagen's argument?

- ▶ Van Inwagen picks a particular paradigm person—a certain judge *J*—and argues that *J* doesn't have the ATDO; the generalization is left implicit.
- ▶ Van Inwagen doesn't actually explicitly appeal (in this paper) to Past or Agglomeration. Rather, he justifies his premise 5 by appeal to the following claim, which follows from the combination of Past and Agglomeration:

If *Q* is a true proposition that concerns only states of affairs that obtained before *S*'s birth, and if *S* can render the conjunction of *Q* and *R* false, then *S* can render *R* false.

Three important readings of 'settled for'

For the purposes of assessing the plausibility of Agglomeration and Entailment, the following three definitions of ' p is settled for x at t ' are especially important:

Definition 1

p is true and nothing x can do at t is such that if x did it, this deed would *be or cause* an event whose occurrence is inconsistent with p (Lewis 1981).

Definition 2

p is true and nothing x can do at t is such that if x did it, p would be false (Lewis 1981, Fischer 1994).

Definition 3

p is true and everything x can do at t is such that if x did it, p would be true.

Lewis on Definition 1

Agglomeration is not true on reading 1.

Here's a counterexample: X is freely raising his arm, and as it happens, X's friend in Japan is saying 'X is raising his arm'.

Both the proposition that X's friend is saying 'X is raising his arm', and the proposition that X's friend is speaking the truth, are settled for X in sense 1.

But their conjunction is not. (See Lewis, 'Are We Free to Break the Laws?')

- Lewis's view: On reading 1, all premises except for Agglomeration are true, but Triviality is false. On reading 3, all premises except for Laws are true, but Triviality is still false.

McKay and Johnson on reading 2

Recall the following disputed principle of counterfactual logic, disputed by Lewis:

Conditional Excluded Middle

Either if P it would be that Q , or if P it would be that not- Q .

If CEM fails, Agglomeration is also not true on reading 2.

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Consider the following scenario: at t , X was able to toss a certain fair coin, but didn't. Even though the coin would have landed Heads or Tails if it had been tossed, it is neither the case that it would have landed Heads if it had been tossed, nor that it would have landed Tails if it had been tossed. (So we have CEM failure.)

Let P be the proposition that the coin never lands Heads, and Q the proposition that it never lands Tails. Both P and Q are “settled for X at t ” in sense 2. But P -and- Q is not, since it would be false if X tossed the coin.

The upshot: reading 3 is the most interesting one. Agglomeration and Entailment are extremely plausible on this reading, since they follow from the corresponding principles for counterfactual logic.

So compatibilists have to reject Past or Laws, both of which seem individually quite intuitive even after we take care not to confuse reading 3 with other possible readings.

The consequence argument and the puzzle of counterfactuals under determinism

Consider van Inwagen's judge in a deterministic world. Both of the following premises are, I think, separately quite plausible:

Past* If J had raised his hand, the intrinsic state of the universe in the distant past would have been just as it actually was.

Laws* If J had raised his hand, the conjunction of all the actual laws of nature would still have been true.

But the combination of these leads to the bizarre result that if J had raised his hand, a contradiction would have been true! Something has to go!

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Lewis argued that it's better to give up Laws*, while I have argued that it's better to give up Past*. Never mind who's right—both views are initially counterintuitive.

How is this relevant to the Consequence Argument?

If we have to give up on Laws* despite its intuitive plausibility, doesn't that undermine our intuitive grounds for thinking that Laws is true?

If we have to give up on Past* despite its intuitive plausibility, doesn't that undermine our intuitive grounds for thinking that Past is true?